

FREE SAMPLE

Guinea Pig Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 51-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Coat Types, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 51 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 46 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/guinea-pig/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free guinea pig care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/guinea-pig/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Lengths appear in inches (in), with centimeters (cm) beside them. Floor space is in square feet (sq ft), which is length times width: 30 by 36 inches is 7.5 sq ft. A guinea pig and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows, with pounds (lb) beside them. Vitamin C is counted in milligrams (mg) per kilogram (kg) of body weight, written mg/kg. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't brought any home yet

Check the law first, on page 23: a guinea pig is legal in every state, with one footnote. Then read pages 4 to 22 in order before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the enclosure, sized by floor area, and the number of guinea pigs, since this species needs company. Use the Budget & Shopping List on page 37 and buy once.

If your guinea pigs are already home

Start with vitamin C on page 11. It is the one requirement almost no other common small pet shares, and it is almost entirely preventable. Then audit the setup against the Setup Checklist, and if anything looks off, go to page 24: the safe waiting window for a guinea pig that has stopped eating is measured in hours.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 35: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 41: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 36: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 43: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 32: Antibiotics & Enterotoxemia | ☐ Page 44: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 45: Equipment & Vet Log |

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian (vet) who sees guinea pigs, often called a cavy-savvy exotic vet. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent is a vet call, not a page in this book, and the window for urgency is short. Find a vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. The law page is not legal advice either. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary sources on page 49.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Cavia porcellus</i> , the guinea pig, also called a cavy
Origin	Domesticated more than 3,000 years ago in the Andes. There is no wild population of this species
Adult size	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm) and 1.5 to 2.6 lb. Boars (males) 900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb); sows (females) 700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb)
Lifespan	4 to 8 years
Diet type	Strict herbivore: unlimited grass hay, about 80% of the diet (page 10)
Vitamin C	Cannot make its own. 10 to 25 mg/kg a day for a healthy adult, 30 mg/kg or more if growing, pregnant, nursing or ill (page 11)
Floor space	7.5 sq ft for one guinea pig, 10.5 sq ft for a pair, with roughly 2 to 4 more sq ft for each additional animal (page 6)
Room	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C) at 30 to 60% humidity. Heat stress can begin at 75°F (24°C) (page 7)
Company	Pairs or small groups. A guinea pig kept alone tends to become withdrawn or depressed (page 18)
Voice	Several distinct vocalizations, from the wheek to the purr (page 17)
Handling difficulty	Beginner, but a prey animal that must be supported at both ends and handled low to the ground
Vaccines required	None for this species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$300 to \$470 for the setup, every item priced, from a cage sized for a pair to the first bag of food, plus \$10 to \$60 for each guinea pig from a shelter or about \$50 at a pet store. An annual wellness exam runs \$50 to \$100. Every line is on page 37.

Monthly ongoing

\$75 to \$185 a month for a pair, which is the recommended minimum: \$60 to \$135 of hay, pellets and fresh vegetables, plus bedding and the vitamin C supplement. Food for one runs \$30 to \$70.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A sick or emergency visit runs \$100 to \$300 or more, and complex problems such as gastrointestinal stasis can push well past that. Neuter and spay fees are set clinic by clinic. None of this is likely if you follow this package, but plan for it.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The wheek, the loud squeal many owners know as the sound a fridge door brings on, is a learned response to expected food, not a fixed instinct.
- Guinea pigs, humans and fruit bats are among the mammals that lost the ability to make their own vitamin C, and in each case the same gene is the one that stopped working.
- Bell pepper carries more vitamin C by weight than an orange, which is why it tops the vegetable list for this species.

The species, coat types, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The pet guinea pig is *Cavia porcellus*, a rodent that has never been found in the wild. It is a fully domesticated species descended from South American wild cavies and bred by Andean peoples for more than 3,000 years, first as livestock and for religious ceremonies and now as one of the world's most popular small pets. It is valued for being vocal, social and gentle. Guinea pigs reached Europe soon after the first European contact with South America, arriving as luxuries kept by the upper classes. The oldest known European remains date to the sixteenth century.

Its Andean ancestry explains most of its habits: it lives in groups, it grazes most of the day (a wild guinea pig can spend up to 80% of it foraging), and it reads a lifted hand as a predator.

Coat types

The most common types are the English or American shorthair, the Peruvian (long-haired) and the Abyssinian (swirled hair). Teddy and Silkie are two other types. Care is the same across them, with two differences: the long-haired types (Peruvian, Silkie and Texel) need brushing every day, and specialty types cost more, from \$100 up, against \$10 to \$60 from a shelter or about \$50 at a pet store for a standard animal.

Size and growth

Adult length	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm).
Adult weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb); sows 700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb). Each animal has its own steady weight, and that figure is the one to track (page 14).
Growth	Babies start nibbling hay, pellets and vegetables within hours of birth while still nursing, and are fully weaned by 2 to 4 weeks. A guinea pig is growing, and eats differently, until about 6 months old (page 10).
Males and females	Boars are larger. Telling the sexes apart is easy to get wrong in young animals (page 22).

Lifespan

4 to 8 years is typical. That is a multi-year commitment, closer in scale to a rabbit or a cat than to a hamster, which lives 2 to 3 years. Plan for the whole span: the diet, the company and a vet who sees guinea pigs for every one of those years, and a second animal for as long as the first lives.

ONE ANIMAL IS NOT THE PLAN

The most commonly skipped part of guinea pig care is the companion, and it quietly doubles most of the numbers in the budget. Guinea pigs are herd animals. Budget for two from day one rather than adding a second later and being surprised by the jump.